

Park Ambassadors Guidebook

CURRICULUM &
RESOURCE
GUIDE



Welcome to Park Ambassadors!

You are about to embark on a journey that will not only give you leadership skills but will also teach you about the importance of parks . You will plan fun activities for all ages, make sure the park is clean and neat and create a welcoming green oasis for all to enjoy. The goal is a welcoming park that people can connect to each other, connect to nature and connect in ways that were not available previously!



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What is a Park Ambassador?

This is a step by step guide to the park ambassador training and duties. Not only will it walk you through how to be a park ambassador but it will also give you all you need to know to keep your park maintained and active!

You will work closely with a community member who will act as your mentor and guide through the entire process. Information and resources for community leaders and how they are involved with the Park Ambassadors are found at the end of this toolkit.

The toolkit is your guidebook to refer to when you need help with an issue, when you need to know what to do in the park every day and also a place to record what happens in the park.



SKILLS OF A PARK AMBASSADOR



Let's Get Started!

TRAINING OVERVIEW

GUIDING PRINCIPLES

CONTRACT



Training Overview

PART ONE:

In each lesson you complete, you receive a badge. You must get all these badges from the park supervisor in order to complete Park Ambassador training .Upon completion of the program, you will get to pick a prize from your favorite lesson!



LISTENER



LEADER



CREATOR



NEIGHBORHOOD
EXPERT



NATURALIST



POLLINATOR



EVALUATOR

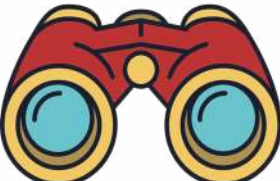


EVENT
COORDINATOR

End of lesson rewards!



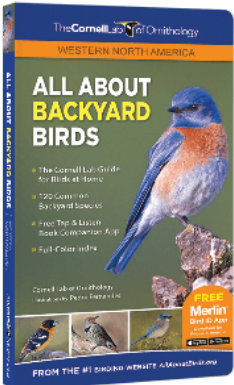
Headphones



Binoculars



Neighborhood
Map



Bird ID Book



Honey Sticks



Journal



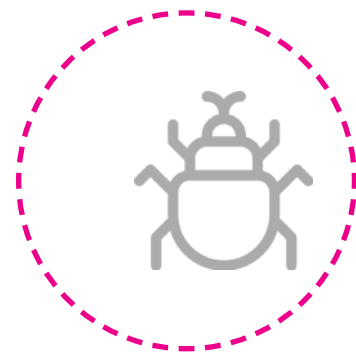
Planner

PART TWO:

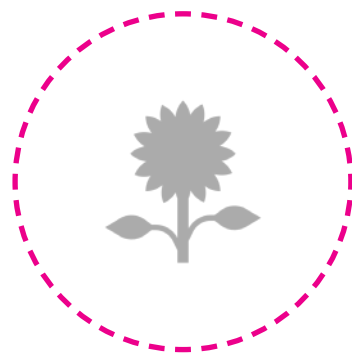
**Maintenance skills
you will learn!**



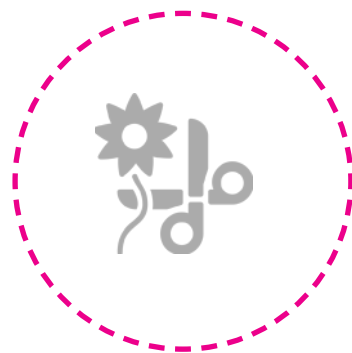
WATERING



PEST CONTROL



PLANTING



PRUNING



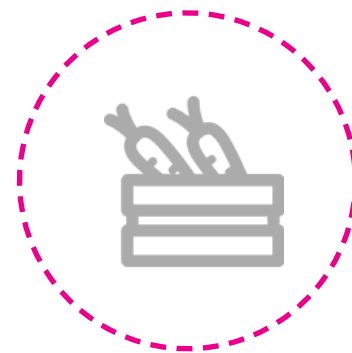
PARK CLEANLINESS



WEEDING



MULCHING



HARVESTING
(IF APPLICABLE)



Guiding Principles

The Park Ambassador Program is based on these core values. YOU will demonstrate these qualities and are expected to reflect them in your role serving your community.

BE RESPONSIBLE

Finish what you start!

When you see a problem in the park, alert your supervisor if its something you do not feel you can handle. Do not try to intervene in situations beyond your control.

BE ATTENTIVE

Listen to park users so they feel heard and respected.

Be a record keeper of what happens in the park. Record what you hear from residents and what suggestions or activities they would like to see in the park.

BE RESPECTFUL

You are the best advocate for the park! Educate and inspire those who use the park.



LISTENER



NEIGHBORHOOD
EXPERT



NATURALIST



EVALUATOR



LEADER



EVENT
COORDINATOR



GOALS

At the end of this training, the Park Ambassadors will be qualified to:

Keep a record or journal of park status and activities

☐

Keep the plants alive and healthy.

☐

Pick up trash so that the park appears clean.

☐

Help organize community events.

☐

Be a pollinator expert!

☐

What else would you like to do?

☐☐☐

LESSON BADGES

MAINTENANCE BADGES

LESSONS

LISTENER

LEADER

CREATOR

NEIGHBORHOOD EXPERT

NATURALIST

POLLINATOR

ENVIRONMENTAL JUSTICE

EVALUATOR

EVENT COORDINATOR

MAINTENANCE

GET STARTED ON
YOUR TRAINING

Park Ambassador Contract

Park Ambassadors are critical to any Park in a Truck project’s success. These trained students are the glue that connect the park to the community. So, the community must find the funds to pay the Park Ambassadors before the search for the job candidates begins.

As part of the design process, the community hires two to three youth for these important roles. Ideally, Park Ambassadors are involved early in the park’s design and assembly.

A community leader must be appointed to oversee the Park Ambassadors’ training process, help them coordinate events and fulfill their other responsibilities.

The park development team should meet with the candidates to go over expectations, job description and the ongoing design process. You may find it helpful to have them submit a short essay on why they are fit for the role.

Once they have accepted the position, it is important for the supervisor to communicate ground rules and structure. We suggest using our sample park ambassador employee contract. [Found in appendix]

Printable copy found here: https://drive.google.com/file/d/1_g_SjBh0Ef18a13vF7cDxVG5EX0VeSR5/view?usp=sharing



Park Ambassador Employee Contract

Job Description:

The Park Ambassador is advocate, educator, manager and liaison for the Park in a Truck initiative. The Park Ambassador’s role is to ensure the success of the park by creating an environment in the park that welcomes the community and manages the park’s maintenance and programs. The Park Ambassador provides information on the park’s design and implementation, provides daily maintenance, assists in rule enforcement and programing for park events.

Process:

The Park Ambassador is a student chosen by the community based on their merit and desire to serve their neighborhood. Each PA must report to a point person such as a community volunteer involved in the park. The Park Ambassador ~~may~~ be involved in the design and build of the park, this is recommended, but not necessary. We recommend two primary park ambassadors as well as an individual who can be “on call” to fulfill the responsibilities if the others are unavailable.

Applicants must:

- ☐ Assume personal and professional responsibilities for his or her actions and activities.
- ☐ Utilize effective time management, notifying supervisor in advance if you are unable to attend work or need to adjust your schedule and being consistent and punctual on workdays.
- ☐ Be willing to learn and participate in a diverse range of support tasks.
- ☐ Prepare for and utilize opportunities of learning afforded by the position.
- ☐ Act in ways that are always responsible and ethical.
- ☐ Be respectful of all community members using the park.
- ☐ Understand that cell phone use is restricted to taking photos of the park events or activities, documenting park damage or issues, for use in research and/or emergencies. No personal calls or texts while on duty.

Applicants should be someone who can:

- ☐ Pay attention to detail, utilize critical thinking skills, and problem-solving abilities.
- ☐ Display courtesy, enthusiasm, and open-minded in all situations.
- ☐ Works well with others and is willing to learn.



Park Ambassador Responsibilities/Activities:

- ☐ Participation in training sessions
- ☐ Maintain the park which includes (as needed) weeding, pruning, watering, sweeping, litter removal
- ☐ Greet park visitors and answering questions
- ☐ Daily set up of toys, loose chairs, lock up of same
- ☐ Educational programming for community children
- ☐ Updating community bulletin board of park events (if applicable)
- ☐ Coordination of community clean-up days
- ☐ Educating park users of history of neighborhood and park’s development
- ☐ Participation in community research and assessment of impacts of park
- ☐ Complete a weekly log & monthly report on the park’s condition

First the Park Ambassadors ~~must~~ complete a training that can be done virtually, but in coordination with the community point person. Roughly 20 hours for both guided lessons and maintenance skills.

This paid position is for two park ambassadors **20 hours a week** from June (end of school year) to Labor Day. The remainder of the year will require **10 hours a week** Saturday for September, October, April, May, and June (depending on when school is over). The day and time of when the park ambassador works in the summer is dependent on the activities and events as outlined by the community.

A suggested weekly schedule for one park ambassador is as follows:

Summer: Monday 10-2 Maintenance			Fall & Spring: Wednesday 4-6 Maintenance		
Wednesday 10-12 Maintenance			Saturday 4-6 Event		
Planning 12-2 Event			Planning		
Total			Total		
5 hours / PA x 2 = 10			5 hours / PA x 2 = 10		
Planning Friday 10-12 Maintenance			Winter: Wednesday 4-6 Maintenance		
Total			Saturday 4-6 Event		
10 hours / PA x 2 = 20			Planning		
			Total		
			5 hours / PA x 2 = 10		

Signature of Park Supervisor

Signature of Park Ambassador

Lesson ONE

YOU ARE A LISTENER

YOU ARE A LEADER

YOU ARE A CREATOR

**YOU ARE A NEIGHBORHOOD
EXPERT**



You are a LISTENER

It applies to this role and everyday life- everyone needs to listen a bit more. When we listen properly, we understand the problem or situation and can solve it more effectively.

By being observant of your environment or people around you, you are showing you are trusting and supportive. Listening is the most underrated form of communication.

Any plant you find, tree you climb, or critter you hold has a story. Listen closely.

Don't just listen with your ears, but with all your senses.

WHAT GETS YOUR ATTENTION?

Observation Skills

Sit and simply focus on your surroundings

Detect an observation with all 5 of your senses

Block out distractions. No music..Be present!

Write down or sketch what you are experiencing. This will make you pay attention to details.



When we spend lots of time and engage with people, places and things, we start to develop relationships with them. You may feel connected to these things and likely feel responsible to care and protect them.

This stands for the environment as a whole and more importantly, your community. The more time you spend exploring your neighborhood and listening to your neighbors, the deeper your connection will be to it. As a park ambassador, it is your duty to tread lightly, respect and care for your environment and those around you.

I invite you to explore a place you've never been before. Visit Fairmount Park in all seasons to pick up on seasonal changes. Pay attention to life around you and cultivate a relationship with a special place of your own.

1. Be fully present.

2. Show empathy

3. Actively listen

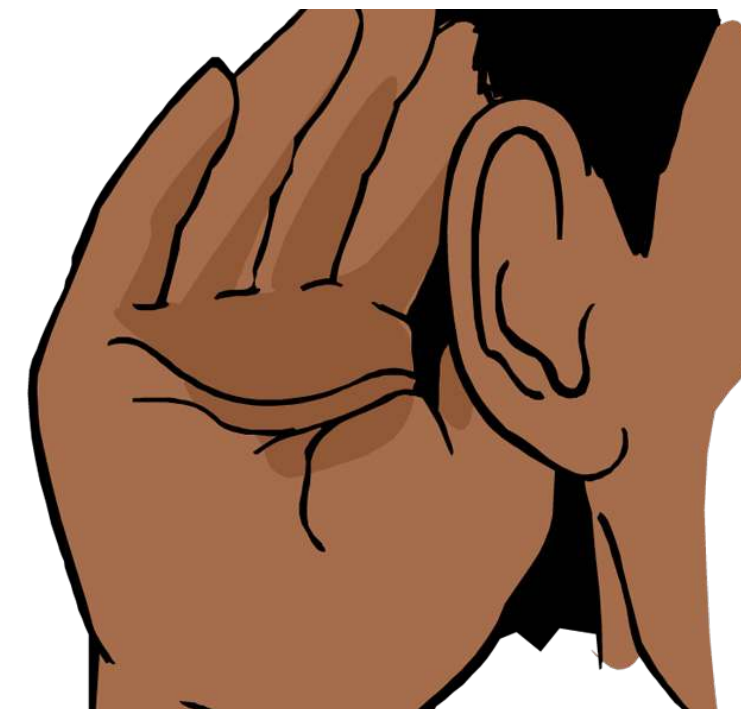
4. Ask open ended questions

5. Be patient and non-judgemental

6. Avoid giving immediate solutions

7. Follow up and check-in

How Can you Listen ?



Listening ACTIVITY

With your partner, share a story about your favorite memory you have outdoors. What did you see, smell, feel, and hear? Why is it your favorite memory? Each partner will draw a picture based on their partner's memory and explain how it relates to the memory.



**Draw on the
next page!**

A large, empty rectangular box with rounded corners and a dark green border, intended for drawing.

You are a LEADER

As a Park Ambassador, you will be given all of the tools you need to become a standout leader in your community and personal life. Through this program, you will grow into someone who knows how to take initiative, gain self confidence, learn motivation skills, improve social skills, and have courage to follow your passion. By learning these skills, you will be able to not only stand up for yourself, but also for others and what is important to YOU! There are many traits that leaders have but the most important one is courage. Taking this step in becoming a Park Ambassador is the first step you will be taking on your journey to lead.



How to be a Leader:



Become a LEADER

You were chosen to be in this position because you want to learn, lead, or are already a natural leader. One can lead in a loud or ambitious way, or in a gentle and quiet way. There are many different types of leaders.



Being a leader means to take initiative and set an example for others.

KEYS FOR BEING A SUCCESSFUL LEADER



COMMUNICATION

Listening



COMMITMENT

Following through on promises made & being present when asked



DELEGATION

Assigning roles or tasks to achieve common goals



INTEGRITY

Morally right decision making. People with integrity earn other's trust for always being honest



MOTIVATION

Recognizing effort and achievement; an incentive



POSITIVITY

Making people feel welcome in the park



Record what stands out to you.

[illegible][illegible]

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

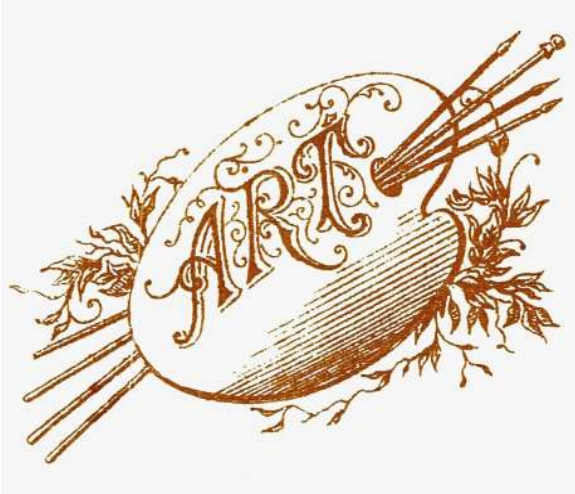
25

You are a CREATOR

creativity is vital for you as it supports your self-expression, problem-solving skills, confidence, emotional well-being, critical thinking, social skills, and imaginative thinking. Encouraging and nurturing your creativity provides you with essential tools to navigate the challenges of adolescence and prepares you for a future that demands innovation and adaptability.



Philomena Williamson, Artist



Why is creativity important?

Self-expression: Creativity provides you with a means to express yourself authentically. You are exploring your identity and discovering your unique perspective. Engaging in creative activities such as art, music, writing, or drama allows you to communicate your thoughts, emotions, and experiences in ways that words alone may not capture.

Problem-solving skills: Encouraging creativity helps foster critical thinking and problem-solving abilities. Creative thinking involves exploring alternative solutions, thinking outside the box, and finding innovative approaches to challenges. By engaging in creative pursuits, you learn to analyze problems from different angles, embrace experimentation, and develop resilience when faced with setbacks.

Confidence and self-esteem: When you engage in creative activities, you have opportunities to showcase your unique talents and abilities. Successfully completing creative projects, receiving positive feedback, and gaining recognition for your creative expressions can significantly boost your self-confidence and self-esteem. It allows you to develop a sense of pride in your accomplishments, leading to increased motivation and a positive self-image.

Emotional well-being: Creativity serves as an outlet for emotional expression and helps you cope with stress, anxiety, and overwhelming emotions. Engaging in creative activities allows you to channel your feelings constructively, release pent-up emotions, and find a sense of calm and balance.

Critical and divergent thinking: Creativity nurtures critical thinking skills by encouraging you to question assumptions, challenge norms, and explore different perspectives. It helps you develop the ability to analyze information critically, think independently, and form your own opinions. Creative pursuits also cultivate divergent thinking, which involves generating multiple ideas and possibilities, fostering adaptability and flexibility in problem-solving.

Imagination and innovation: Creativity nurtures imagination and encourages you to think beyond the boundaries of the known. It sparks your curiosity, ignites your imaginations, and fosters a sense of wonder and exploration. By embracing your creativity, you can develop the capacity to innovate, solve complex problems, and contribute fresh ideas to your communities and the world.

How can you CREATE?

Collect leaves, sticks, and rocks to create an animal made out of collected materials. At the bottom, write what led you to choose the animal you went with. Was it your favorite animal? Was it the color? Be as creative as you want and have fun!

Tip:
use a larger
piece of paper if
necessary!

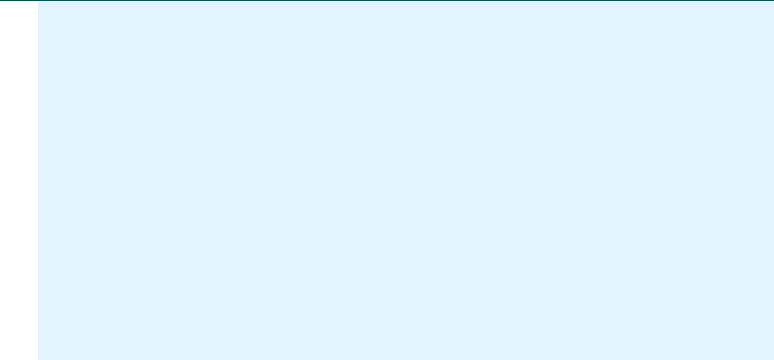
Examples:



You are a NEIGHBORHOOD EXPERT

To serve your community best, you must know it well. Park visitors may look to you for directions or suggestions to find a snack. Knowing how people get to the park and what resources are in the neighborhood will show visitors you care and are trustworthy.

What community groups are active around you?



As part of a neighborhood expert, you should also know about the non social systems that make up your community. Do you know where the Schuylkill River is in relation to you? Do you know when you're heading East vs. West ? How walkable is your neighborhood? Why is this important?

These factors impact the park by how it is designed. We do a similar process called "Analysis" where we try to understand how a site fits within a neighborhood and its larger context. We love to find inspiration from the character and spirit of place!

HOW TO GET INVOLVED!

Develop a connection between yourself and local representatives, charities and businesses to help identify manageable projects where you can have a real impact.

Help with community service groups like serving the food pantry
or helping shovel your elderly neighbors sidewalks!

Go on daily walks with your friends, waving to neighbors, getting out and about brings life to the community and encourages others to do the same.



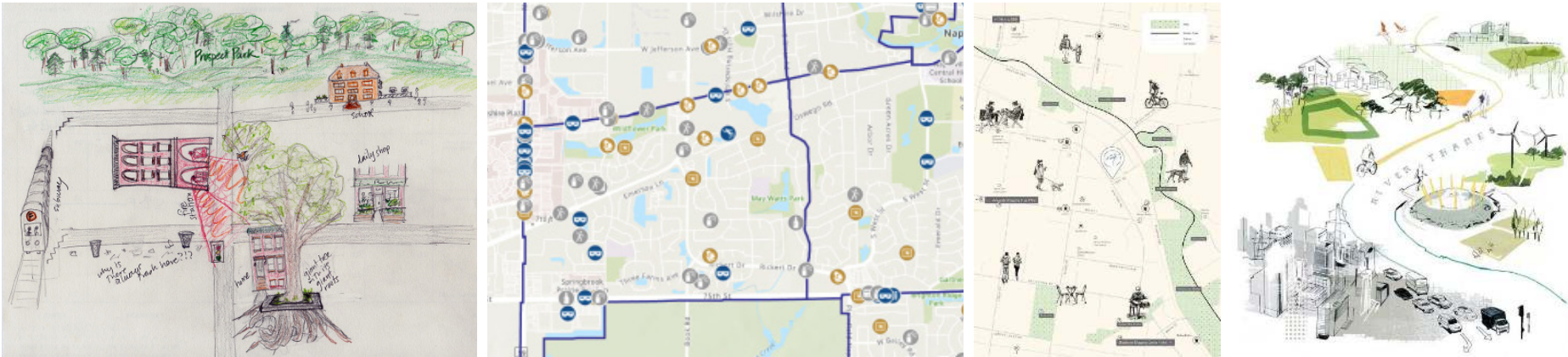
We are going to make asset maps of your neighborhood. Take a walk around with your map and clipboards. Take pictures, sketch & take notes. Here are two approaches:

Option 1
Find your park site on Google Maps and print out a five block radius map.

Option 2
Take a blank piece of paper and illustrate your experience. Record your route, doesn't have to be accurate.

- THINGS TO INCLUDE:
- Corner stores
 - Bus stops
 - Libraries
 - Schools
 - Restaurants
 - Wildlife
 - Friendly neighbors

Examples



Lesson TWO

YOU ARE A NATURALIST

WHAT ARE POLLINATORS

ENVIRONMENTAL JUSTICE



You are a NATURALIST

Why is this important?
Why should we care?

- ...to understand the value of biodiversity.
- ...to see what impact humans have on our Earth
- ...processing traditional ecological knowledge
- ...environmental stewardship
- ...to preserve access, experience and value of unique cultural and natural resources
- ...educating the public
- ...monitoring climate change
- ...protecting species that we've harmed
- ...Nature provides us with joy, inspiration & discovery.

Naturalists are avid observers of the natural world. They take detailed field notes about species they are observing and how that species fits into the larger ecosystem.

Take a look on the next two pages to discover local birds and trees you can find right in your neighborhood!

Hint: during the colder months the trees may be harder to identify.

Birds of Philadelphia



American goldfinch



American Robin



Blue Jay



Mourning Dove



American Woodcock



Eastern Bluebird



Bald Eagle



Song Sparrow



American Crow



Gold-winged Warbler



Barred Owl



American Tree Sparrow



Coopers Hawk



American goldfinch



Cerulean Warbler



American Hornbeam



Red Maple



Sweet Gum



Pin Oak



Serviceberry



White Ash



Pignut Hickory



Silver Linden

Trees of Philadelphia



Ginkgo



Swamp White Oak



Green Ash



Cherry



Redbud



London Plane



Zelkova



Callery Pear



Thornless Honey Locust



American Elm



White Oak



Franklinia



What characteristics help us to identify trees?
What essential details and observations are necessary for proper tree identification?

Collect two different leaves. Trace them by putting them behind them paper and rubbing a crayon over top to reveal the leaf in the box.

Make notes about their leaf margin and coloring.
Then try to identify what species they are and fill in the box.



What is a POLLINATOR?

Part of the reason we need parks and green space is to help pollinators. Lots of pollinators is a sign of a healthy and thriving ecosystem because they contribute to the reproduction of fruit and flowers.

You must learn not be afraid of bees, birds or these other critters as they're just trying to do their job!



Butterflies



Honey Bees



Wasps



Hummingbirds

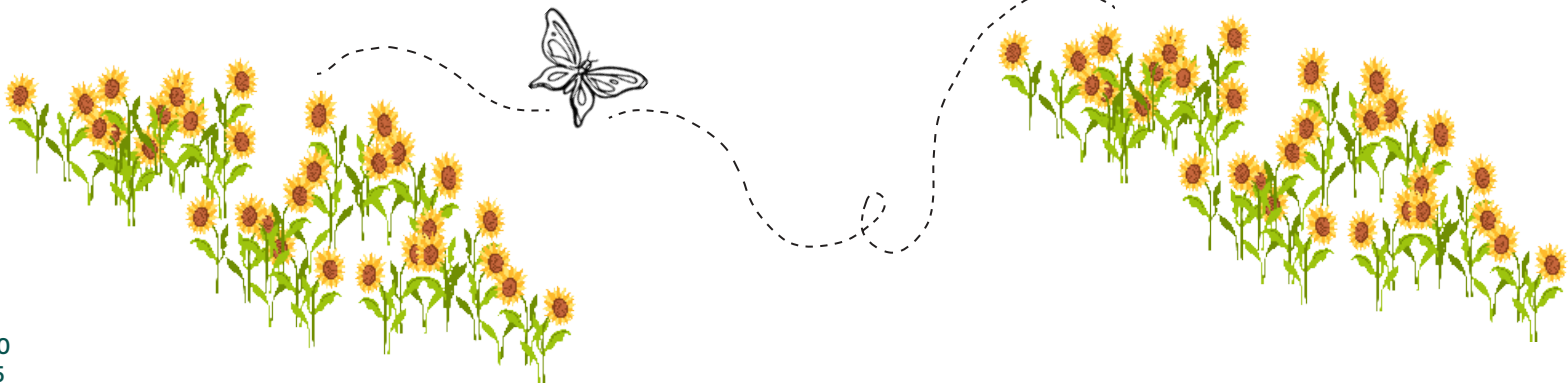


Moths

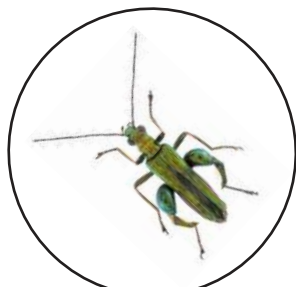
A pollinator travels to collect nectar and pollen. When it visits a flower, it collects pollen on it's feet from the male part of the flower called the stamen.

It travels to another plant of the same type with the pollen on it's feet.

While getting the nectar from this flower, the bee leaves behind the pollen on the female part of the flower. This is called the stigma and the process is how plants reproduce to provide fruits and flowers



Any animal that transfers pollen grains from flower to flower in order for a plant to reproduce.



Beetles



Flies



Bats



Song Birds



4,000
Bee species
in the U.S.



of our food is
dependent
upon
pollinators



Honeybees must visit
5 MILLION flowers
to make **1 PINT** of
honey

Try to find all the pollinators shown on a walk!

HOW CAN WE HELP?

Use a variety of native plants that support pollinators all year long

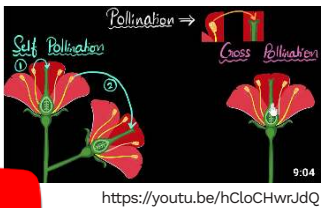


Create pollinator habitat & deter from using pesticides



Spread the importance of pollinators

Buy local honey and produce to support local farmers and beekeepers



<https://youtu.be/hCloCHwrJdQ>



https://youtu.be/eqsXc_aefKI

Pollinator Type

Location

FIELD STUDY

Gangsta Gardener: Ron Finley Project



Gangsta:
projecting strength on one’s own terms, hip, cool,
innovative, revolutionary, resolute, vital, the cutting edge.

The Ron Finley Project is teaching communities how to transform food deserts into food sanctuaries, and teaching individuals how to regenerate their lands into creative business models. We envision and want to facilitate a world where gardening is gangsta!

Ron Finley TED Talk

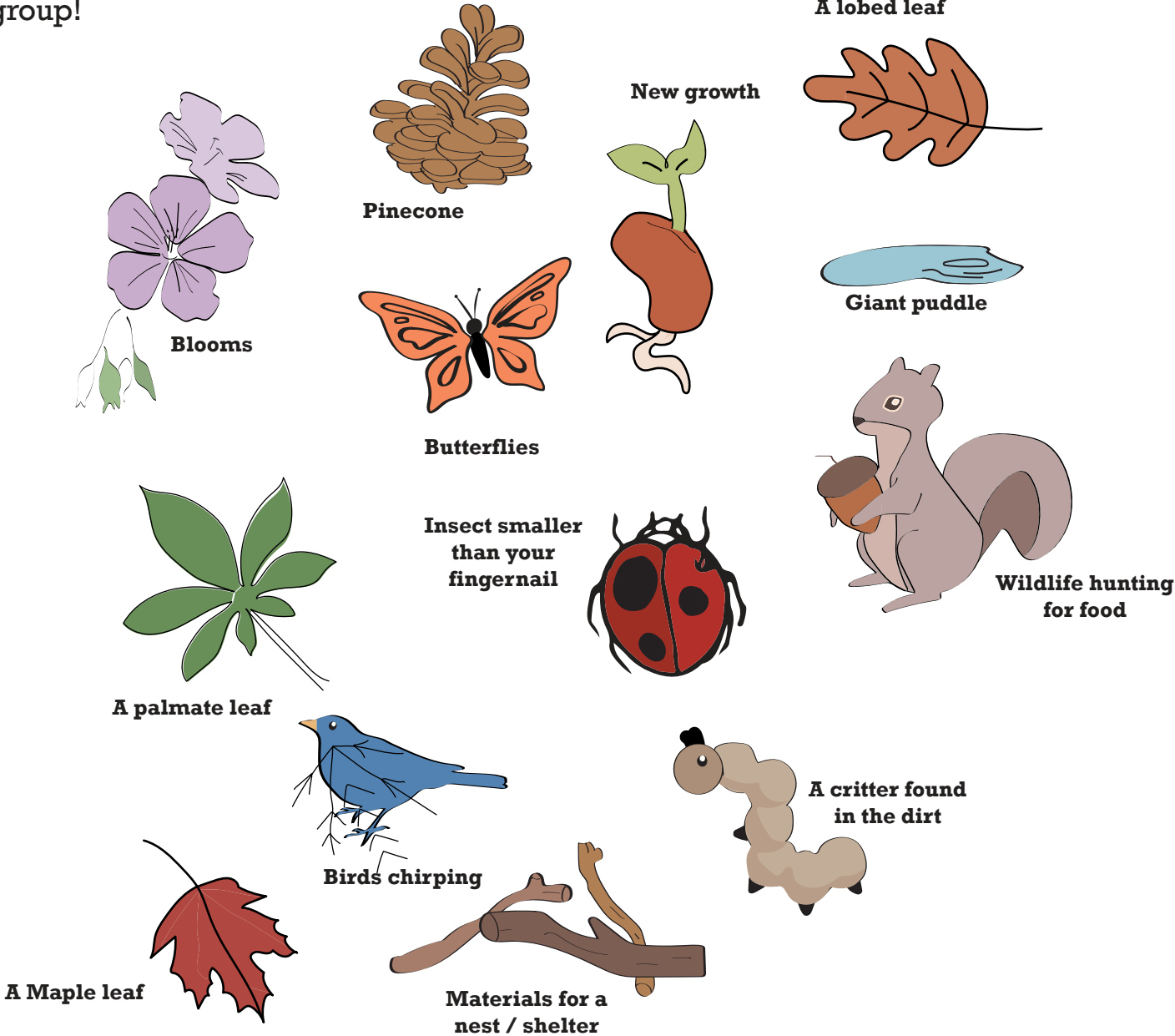


A guerilla gardener in South Central LA | Ron Finley
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=EzZzZ_qpZ4w

Scavenger Hunt

Search your neighborhood for the things you learned about in this chapter. Record your findings and share with the group!

- ☐ Blooms
- ☐ Pinecone
- ☐ Butterflies
- ☐ New growth
- ☐ Critter tracks
- ☐ A palmate leaf
- ☐ A Maple leaf
- ☐ Birds chirping
- ☐ A lobed leaf
- ☐ Insect smaler than your fingernail
- ☐ Wildlife hunting for food
- ☐ A critter found in the dirt
- ☐ Giant puddle
- ☐ Materials for a shelter / nest



What is ENVIRONMENTAL JUSTICE?

What is it?

Environmental justice is the idea that everyone should have the same access to a clean and healthy environment, regardless of things like race, income, or where they live. It's not fair if some people have to breathe polluted air, drink dirty water, or live near dangerous waste sites just because of who they are or where they live.

What does this mean?

Environmental justice aims to address these inequalities and make sure that everyone has the same chance to live in a safe and healthy environment.

How can YOU help?

Here are 10 ways you can help with environmental justice right now !

1.Learn about environmental issues: lets look at a map of your neighborhood - where are the parks? streams? trees? can we research areas that are polluted?

2.Get involved: you can join or start environmental clubs at school, participate in local environmental groups, or attend events that promote environmental justice.

3.Speak up: contact your block captain or ward leader to help with things you might want to change in your neighborhood

4.Reduce waste: you can reduce the amount of waste you generate by using reusable water bottles, lunch containers, and bags. you can also recycle and compost when possible.

5.Conserve energy: you can turn off lights when you leave a room, unplug electronics when they're not in use, and use energy-efficient light bulbs.

6.Plant trees: you can plant trees and other vegetation in their community to help improve air quality and provide habitat for wildlife.

7.Choose sustainable products: you can look for products that are made from sustainable materials or have minimal

environmental justice is about fairness and making sure that everyone has equal access to a clean and healthy environment.



Reflection

There is environmental concern no matter where you live. It's not always visible and sometimes these issues start to seem normal. Consider your own neighborhood and respond to these questions.

How many trees are on the street that you live ?

Draw your dream frontyard or backyard in the box below!

Biodiversity

The variety of life and richness of species on the Earth or in a particular region.

Climate Change

Large shifts in weather patterns due to significant global change because of fossil fuels, deforestation, and some farming practices.

Environmental Stewardship

is the careful and responsible management of the natural environment.

Watershed

is the area of land that drains to a specific

Environmental Hero

Come up with your own definition of what an environmental hero is !

Has your street or home ever flooded?

Why do you think it is important to address these difficulties?

Why or why not do you think you have a responsibility to care for and protect the environment?

Environmental Injustice in PHILADELPHIA!

How has your city been impacted by environmental injustice?

Philadelphia, like many cities, has been impacted by environmental injustice in the past. For example, some neighborhoods in Philadelphia have been exposed to higher levels of pollution and other environmental problems than others. This is often because these neighborhoods are home to low-income residents or communities of color, who may not have had the power or resources to fight against environmental hazards.

Let's list some of the things that we can do to help our neighborhood be healthier :

-



REFLECTION:

After reading the Philly is taking action section, what part would you like to work on? Why?



Philly is taking ACTION!

Greenworks Philadelphia: In 2009, Philadelphia launched a sustainability plan called Greenworks Philadelphia. The plan includes goals to reduce greenhouse gas emissions, improve air and water quality, and promote green jobs and economic development.

Philadelphia Energy Authority: In 2010, Philadelphia created the Philadelphia Energy Authority to help the city transition to clean energy and reduce energy costs. The authority has launched programs to promote solar energy, energy efficiency, and other clean energy technologies.

Tree planting: Philadelphia has a goal to plant 300,000 trees by 2025 to help improve air quality and provide habitat for wildlife.

Water management: Philadelphia has implemented a program called Green City, Clean Waters to improve the health of its waterways by reducing stormwater runoff and promoting green infrastructure, such as rain gardens and green roofs.

Community engagement: Philadelphia has worked to engage communities in environmental justice efforts by holding public meetings, creating community gardens, and providing educational resources to schools and residents.

Lesson THREE

YOU ARE AN EVALUATOR

**YOU ARE AN EVENT
COORDINATOR**



You are an EVALUATOR

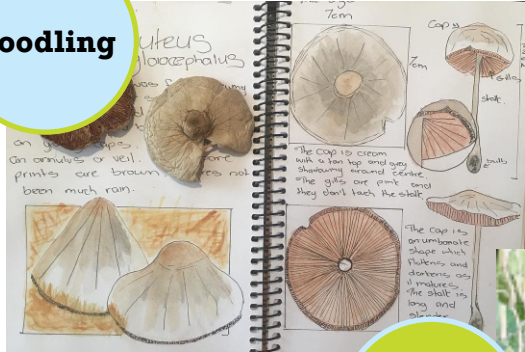
Because you will be in the park the most, you will come to know it best. You will notice the subtle differences over the seasons, know who frequents the park the most and if it is providing habitat to animals.

On the right page you will find an example of the park diary you will keep. Think of it as your work log. It contains both your weekly maintenance tasks and space for your own observations and recordings. Each weeks tasks vary so it is important to stay on the correct week. Once you finish each task, mark the box with your initials to signal to your cohorts that the task is finished.

It is important to track these changes, so you can recognize patterns over time or so new park ambassadors can know what to do!

Keeping track of the responsibilities shows communication between the park ambassadors. Also, in the event that there was a problem, request or comment, it is important to record it so every Park Ambassador is aware. The record book should be kept in the tool shed where it remains at the park at all times. This is how your supervisors will assess the week's work and hours!

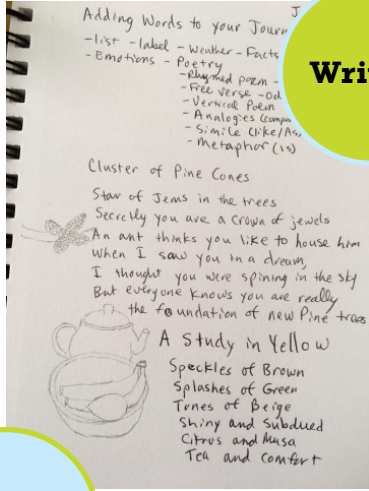
Doodling



Here are some examples and/ or inspiration on ways to capture your observations in nature!



Writing



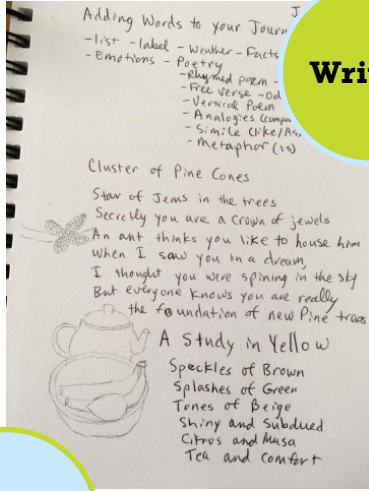
Photography



Sketching



Poetry





Park Diary

Take a deeper look at your park. Write down what you love about it. Write down what could use some work.



EVALUATE!

What Park are you Evaluating?

- ☐ kids playing
- ☐ birds singing
- ☐ flowers growing
- ☐ bees buzzing
- ☐ people on benches
- ☐ dogs playing
- ☐ trees growing
- ☐ people laughing

What is doing well in the park?

This could use some work:

notes

Check the box if you notice any of these activities going on in your park!

You are an EVENT COORDINATOR

Coordinating community activities falls under civic responsibility; it is a way we can give back to the community and help others. It is a great way to show initiative and develop skills that will help with school and your future career!

2-3 activities or events per month are recommended so the park is consistently used and more people become aware that this park is cared for and loved.

The event itself can be whatever you want it to be from a science day to a pumpkin carving competition to an ice cream social. One aspect of planning is coming up with the activity itself, if you are ever out of ideas, it would always be easy to put up a list for suggestions or ask someone who is really involved with the community.



After you know what the event is going to be, you need to promote the event so as many people get involved as possible. You might think to make posters or hand out flyers.

However you decide to promote the event, make sure the date and time are bold and obvious.



Make a social media account for your park or under your community organization



to promote events and keep neighbors updated on what's happening in the park!

EVENT IDEAS

Monarch festival	Chess tournament	Dance classes	Neighborhood BBQs
Floral arranging 101	Meditation	Tie-dye	DIY pizza night
Scavenger hunt	Terrarium making	Kite making	Birdfeeder making
Earth Day celebration	Easter egg hunt	Photography gallery	Chili cook off competition
Woodworking workshop	How to grow herbs	Craft bizarres	Cookie exchange
Garden storytime	Poetry readings	Drum circles	Farmers market
Insect study	Lantern festival	Art classes	Ice cream social
Wildflower walk	Yoga	Pumpkin carving	Medicinal plants seminar



Use this template to create a mock event.

This is a good guideline to use when planning events for the park.

Event name _____

Date _____

Location _____

Activity _____

Purpose _____

Coordinator _____

Expected # of people _____

Budget _____

Budget source _____

Promotion strategy _____

➡ **Where?** _____

Set up crew:

Clean up crew:

Set up time:

Supplies

Are you going to need additional tables and chairs? or

Will you have music? or

Will the event committee provide the food? or potluck? or

Snacks or Meal?

What're you having? _____

From where? _____





MAINTENANCE:

GET STARTED ON
YOUR TRAINING!

OVERVIEW
CALENDAR
WEEDING
PEST CONTROL
PRUNING
WATERING
PLANTING TREES & SHRUBS
PLANTING PERENNIALS
SUPPLIES CHECKLIST
TOOLSHED

Planting Maintenance Overview

This is an simple overview of care for the plants in your park.
The following pages will further explain each task.

WEEDING

- When the park is first established, weeding must be done weekly.
- Many weeds must be dug out with a trowel and is easier if the soil is moist.
- For common weeds and tips see pg. 31 for an extensive guide of weeds or find the manual in the Resource Library

PEST CONTROL

The Park has been designed to attract pollinators who will assist in pest control.

PRUNING

Use hand pruning tools for all shrub and perennial pruning.

Prune shrubs only as necessary to guide future structural shape or to remove dead or diseased material.

WATERING

- The Park will need careful attention to watering in the first two years.
- Use a rainwater guide to track rainfall.
- If you need to water, thoroughly soak planting area(s) by either turning on water for 3 hours using soaker hose or water by hand.
- Apply water slowly that it does not run off and long enough to penetrate soil to a depth of 6"-8" in planting beds.
- **If the top 2" of soil are dry, it is time to water**
- Often if plants reach the visible wilt point it's time to water. If the soil is moist, there may be another issue.

CHECKLIST

- ☐ Pest or disease evidence
- ☐ Weeds/ invasive plants
- ☐ Condition of mulch
- ☐ Dead or dying plants
- ☐ Cleaning up trash & debris
- ☐ Watering

TRACK:

 rainfall for adequate water

 Temperatures both freezing and hot

SEEDS

Seed catalogs have much more diversity than buying seedlings at a nursery. They also contain great information

1. Read seed catalogs to decide what you would like to grow and how to care for the plants
2. Order seeds for veggies and annuals
3. Start your seeds indoors using the instructions on the packet

BULBS

1. Order bulbs from August - October
2. Plant bulbs (between Halloween & Thanksgiving)
3. Dead head flowers after bloom
4. Wait for foliage to turn yellow; then remove

PERENNIALS

1. Plant in early spring through summer
2. Cut back existing perennials or grasses in early spring

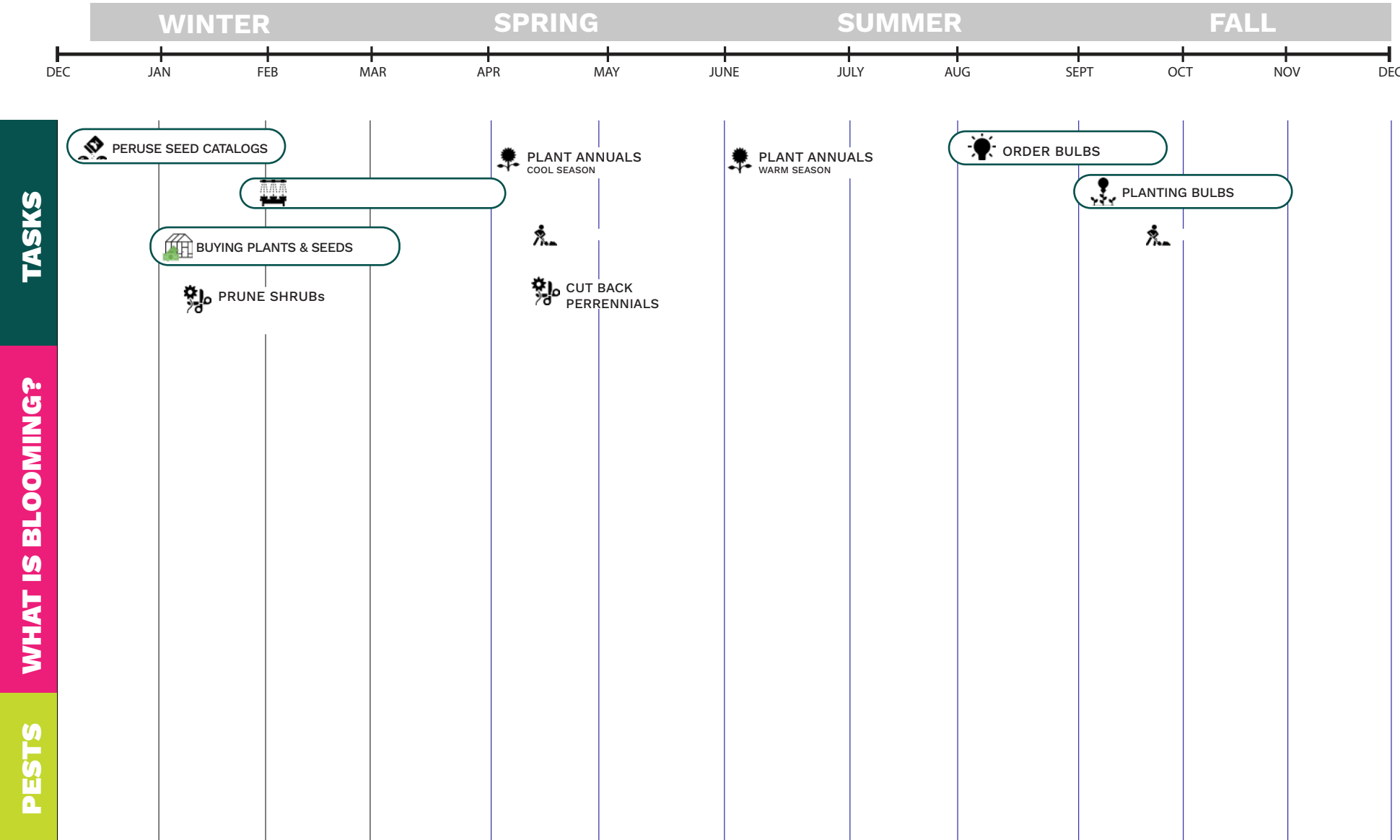
ANNUALS

1. Buy desired annual flowers
2. Cool season annuals such as pansies and snapdragons can be planted in April
3. Warm season annuals like begonias and impatiens can be planted in late May
4. Annual seeds such as cosmos and zinnias can be planted directly in soil
5. Keep well watered

MULCHING

- Mulch all planting beds with leaf mold or mature, triple shredded hardwood mulch.
- Maintain mulch throughout planting beds.
- **Maintain mulch at a depth of 2" to 3"**, being careful not to over-mulch.

1. Write the plant name and create a line or shape using the bloom color to indicate when they will bloom and for how long..
- 2.. Do the same for garden pests. Knowing when to expect the pests will help prevent them and keep the plants from dying.

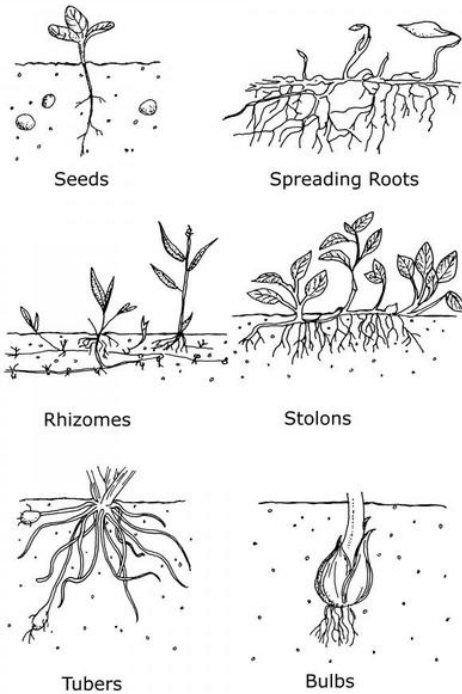


Weeding

Essentially, a weed is a plant growing where we don't want it to. But this is natural behavior for plants, they are adaptive in the way of taking over available space. Weeds have evolved to growing quickly, thriving in harsh conditions and spreading easily.

They still contribute good things like releasing oxygen and performing photosynthesis. The problem is, they compete with the good plants for essential resources such as water, nutrients and sunlight.

It is important to keep weeds under control, so they do not overpower the park plantings. It is critical that you can distinguish weeds from good plants, so you do not accidentally tear out the keepers.



Broad-leaf Plantain



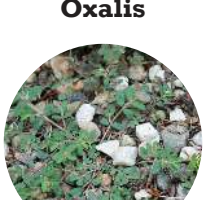
Dandelion



Dead Nettle



Crabgrass



Oxalis



Purslane



Foxtail



Pennsylvania Smartweed



Garlic Mustard



Do it Daily
Weed often to keep them under control.

Take the pulled weeds and throw them into the compost. If left in planting beds, they will root again.

Rain
Weed after it rains so the ground is soft.

Watering
When watering the garden, water only the plants, not the whole bed to avoid the weeds.

Fertilizing
Same goes when fertilizing, concentrate on the plants.

Mulch
This will help prevent weed growth by blocking sunlight.

Get to the root
When pulling weeds, ALWAYS make sure to get the entire root. If the root isn't pulled, the weed will grow back faster and stronger. Use a hand rake.

Research
If a certain weed is being relentless or you're having trouble with a spot, do research to problem solve.



Pest Control



Most pests we commonly see in our gardens are mostly more annoying than anything; that's why we call them pests. The most harm they are going to do is eat the plants leaving holes in foliage or sometimes crops. There are ways to get around these pesky critters, but do your research because some bugs might be the good kind!

Spotted Lanternfly

The invasive species hatches in the spring and feed on a species called the Tree of Heaven. They fly, but DON'T bite. You SHOULD kill them.



COMMON GARDEN PESTS



Japanese Beetle



Aphids



Mealy Bugs



The best natural weed killers



Natural Armor

Avenger

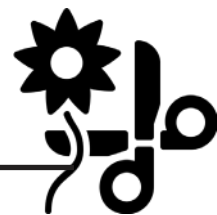
Green Gobbler 20% Vinegar

Doctor Kirchner



<https://youtu.be/LUSbQaXmM4>

Pruning



When you prune a shrub or tree correctly, you encourage new, healthy growth. Pruning may also result in more flowering or just making the form of the plant more attractive.

Doing this in the winter will allow you to see the full structure of the shrub or plant without obstruction of foliage. It's important to do some prior research before this step because some plants respond better to pruning after flowering.

TIPS FOR PRUNING

1. Assess the tree's pruning needs.

Look at the shape from different angles. Identify any dead or damaged branches.

2. Remove the weakest first.

Remove growth that is less than a pencil thick as well as growth that makes the tree or shrub look straggly.

3. Make an undercut.

Using a handsaw, make a shallow undercut (cut upwards from the underside where the branch attaches to the trunk. Do not cut all the way through.

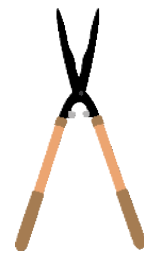
4. Make an undercut.

Place your handsaw a few inches beyond your undercut and cut downwards through the branch from top to bottom. This removes the weight of the branch.

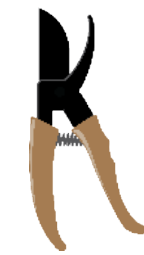
5. Final cut

Remove the remaining stub by cutting the branch above the collar. Cut slowly and evenly using long strokes. Make sure the surface is smooth and flat

WHAT YOU'LL NEED:

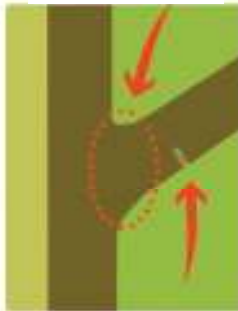


LOPPERS



HAND PRUNERS

Branch collar



First cut

Second cut



Final cut



Before pruning



Properly pruned

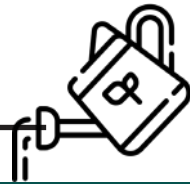


Improperly pruned



<https://youtu.be/IQhmIK-0HOc>

Watering



Watering is critical for all plants at an early age. Like a baby, they need more care and attention during early development. Watering might be the most important part of park maintenance.

From March to October, there should be a regular, consistent watering regimen. During the summer months, plants are prone to drought so remember to be attentive to when it last rained. A good rule of thumb is to test the top few inches of the soil. If the soil is dry, the plants have absorbed all the available water and therefore need more.



<https://youtu.be/ueQCISD5AdM>

Take your time to provide a nice steady & even shower

Soak the root zone

Water only when needed

Water in the morning

Use a tool that evenly distributes water, like a watering wand

Water too quickly or apply too much water at once

Water the foliage or above ground part of the plant

Overwater. Too much moisture is damaging

Make the plants suffer through the hottest part of the day with no water

use a hose without a head or a sprinkler, it is inefficient

Planting Trees & Shrubs

Trees and shrubs are very hardy, yet they are delicate in their early years, so they need careful attention when planting.

1. Decide location

Research what conditions your tree likes. Shade or full sun? Dry or lots of wetter conditions? Assess the site and find the best spot for it to thrive.

Also consider the tree in full maturity. Where will it serve the park the best?

Plant at least 3ft. from pavement/ fencing. 15ft. away from buildings and electrical wires.

2. Prune & remove

Prune all dead and/or damaged branches.

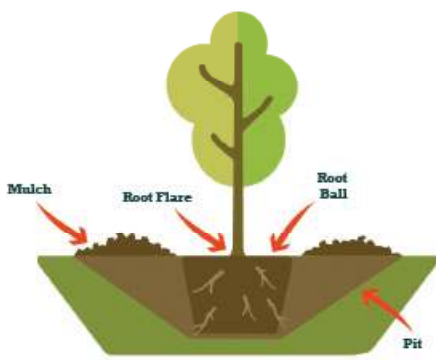
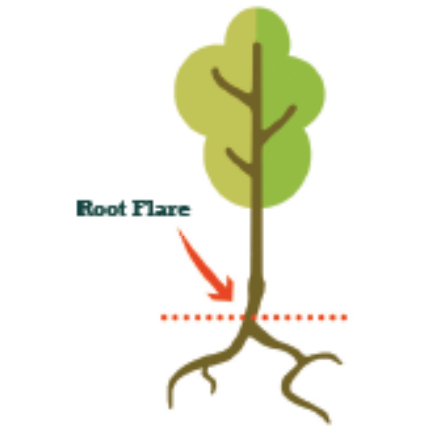
Not sure if the branch is dead? Scrape your fingernail against the bark. If it is green, it is still alive.

Carefully lay your tree on its side and roll the container back and forth. This loosens the root ball. Stand the tree up and pull up at the trunk's base while holding the container. Cut the plastic pot if necessary.

3. Roots

The roots are probably growing in a circle from the container. Use a soil knife to make an x cut across the bottom. Remove 1-2 in. of outer roots and soil.

31



4. Roots flare

Find the root flare (this is where the trunk widens and flare out into roots at the trunk's base). It's harder to find on smaller trees. Remove a bit of soil to find it.

5. Dig & test

Dig a hole that is twice the width of the root ball and deep enough so the root flare is just above the soil. Place the tree in the hole to test the depth and width. The root flare should be flush with the soil surface.

6. Fill

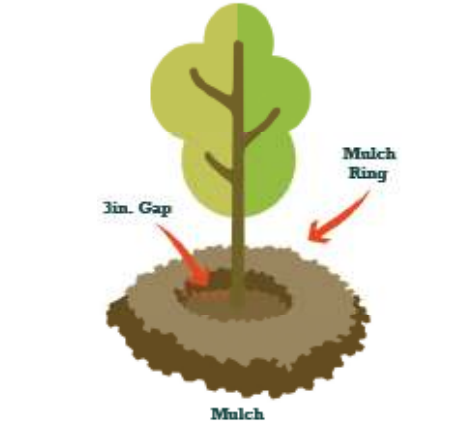
Place the tree in the hole. Make sure the trunk is straight and roots are loose. Return the soil to the hole, packing it tight so all air pockets are filled.

7. Mulch

Make a ring 3in. away from root flare. The ring should be 3in. deep and 3ft. wide.

Water

Water the new tree 15-20 gallons a week from March to December. Watering for the initial two years is critical for its development.



Planting Perennials

Perennials are plants that can survive through the winter and will bloom for a short duration. Once planted, Find out what preferred amount of sunlight and water your perennials need, then place them accordingly.

Full sun
6hrs or more

Partial sun
2hrs or more of direct or dappled sun

Dappled light only
(Direct sun is too harsh)

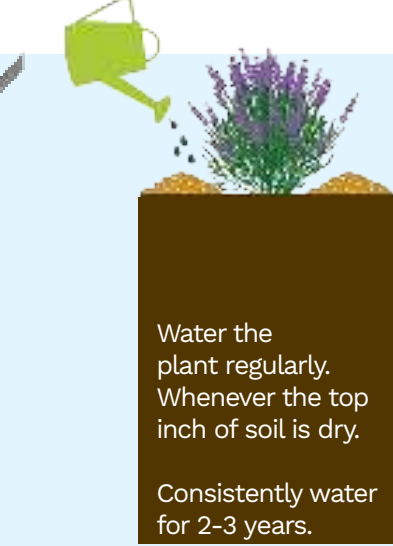
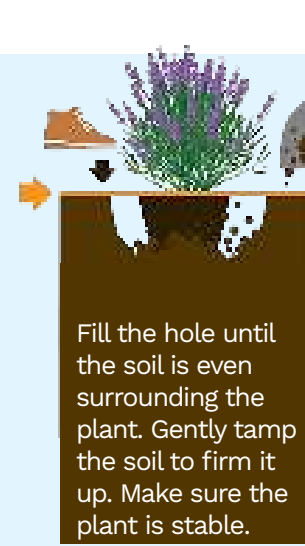
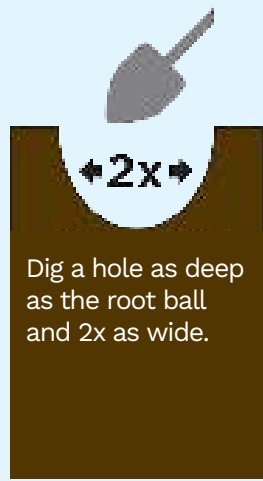


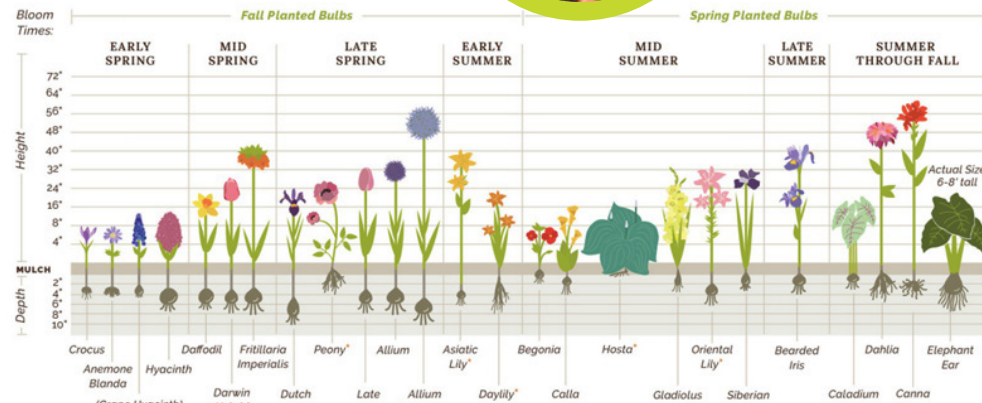
Illustration Credit: MyGardenLife

Planting Bulbs

Bulb planting typically happens in the fall before the ground freezes. Determine what type of light the bulb needs and find a spot accordingly.

You can either plant a large row or group of bulbs at once by digging a large hole, or indivually by digging single holes.

Determine how deep the hole should be dug, place the bulb tip up, roots down. Cover with excess soil and mulch. Water.



Materials

Park ambassadors will need a variety of materials based on the scope of work they intend to do. A shed and lock provided by the community group is recommended to securely store materials on site.

SHARED

- ☐ Garden rake
- ☐ Rounded, pointed tip shovel (32” or longer)
- ☐ Squared transfer shovel (32” or longer)
- ☐ Garden hoe
- ☐ Wheelbarrow
- ☐ Loppers (long-handled pruners)
- ☐ Leaf rake
- ☐ Foam kneeling pads (2-3)
- ☐ Flexible plastic tubs with handles
- ☐ Tape measure
- ☐ Watering can
- ☐ Watering wand
- ☐ Water hose (at least 50’, 100’ rec.)
- ☐ Sunscreen & insect repellent
- ☐ Trashbags

Watering Essentials

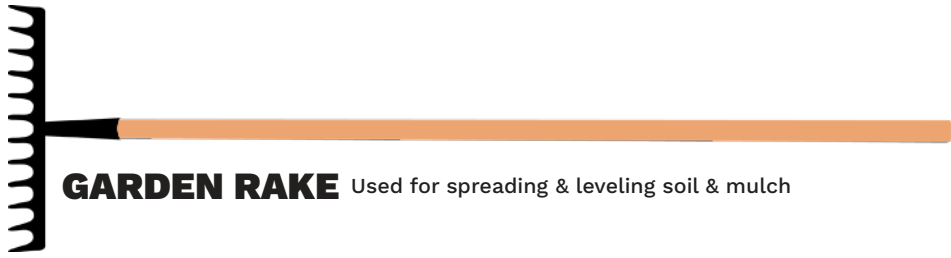


INDIVIDUAL

- ☐ Gardening gloves
- ☐ Old shoes & clothes that can get dirty
- ☐ Pruning shears or snips
- ☐ Hand shovel
- ☐ Hand rake
- ☐ Hori-hori (garden knife)
- ☐ Weeder
- ☐ Plant guide
- ☐ Clipboard
- ☐ Sketchbook
- ☐ Water Bottle
- ☐ Hat/sun protection



It is up to the Park Ambassador’s to keep the tool shed clean and organized. Each Park Ambassador is responsible for their own tools to establish accountability, it is part of their “work uniform.”



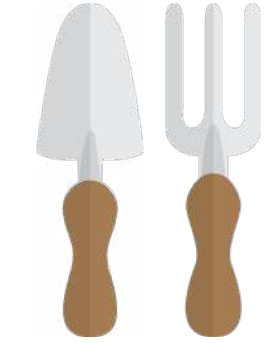
GARDEN RAKE Used for spreading & leveling soil & mulch



POINTED SHOVEL



LEAF RAKE Collecting debris and leaves from planting beds & gravel walkways



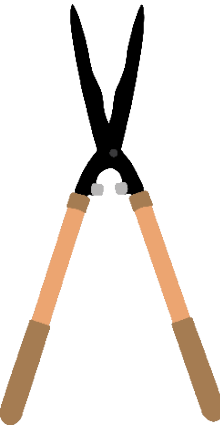
HAND SHOVEL & HAND RAKE

Used for planting, weeding potting, transplanting and just about anything.



PRUNERS

For basic pruning, cut backs and dead-heading



LOPPERS

This tool makes limbing up trees very easy and shrub pruning a breeze.

The Toolshed



TAPE MEASURE

For spacing when planting and recording growth



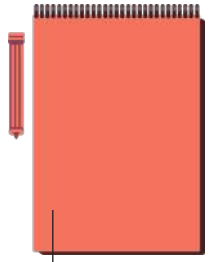
CAMERA APP

For documenting your hard work



PICTURE THIS

Plant identifier app



SKETCHBOOK

For note taking, observations, reminders, or trying to illustrate nature’s beauty



PROTECT YOURSELF!

Glossary

Adaptation

A characteristic of behaviors that make it wasier to survive in a particular habitat

Biodiversity

The variety and abundance of living organism that exist in an area.

Biology

The study of all living things

Biomass

All living material in a habitat

Biomimicry

Copying designs and processes from nature

Carbon dioxide

A gas that is a mixture of carbon and oxygen. People and animals breathe carbon dioxide out; trees and other plants absorb

Carbon footprint

The negative impact something or someone has on the environment, based on the amount of carbon emitted from

Climate change

A shift in Earth’s weather patterns relative to long-term average conditions; effects include rising temperatures and changing weather patterns such as increased frequency of intense rainfall events or declining snowfall

Compost

A mixture of decayed organic matter that adds nutrients to soil

Confluence

The place where two or more rivers or streams meet and flow together

Conserve

To protect from loss or overuse

Deciduous

Describes the type of trees that lose their leaves in fall.

Decomposers

Organisms that cause decay or break down the bodies of dead plants and animals into components that can be reused

Dormant

In an inactive state for a period of time

Ecology

The study of relationships between living things and the environment around them.

Ecosystem

The entirity of organisms and their environment.

Endangered

At risk for becoming extinct

Erosion

The process of washing or wearing away, such as the effect of wind and rain on soil

Evergreen

Plants whose leaves stay green throughout the year

Fertilization

The process of combining pollen from one flower with cells of another flower, allowing the flower to make seeds

Food chain

The relationships among a group of living things based on the flow of energy from food

Greenhouse

A building designed to control light and heat in order to grow and protect plants

Groundwater

Water that is underground in the soil or in spaces in and between rocks

Habitat

A place in which an organism is normally able to find the resources it needs for survival

Herbaceous layer

The layer above the forest floor, where ferns, grasses, and other plants grow

Herbicide

A chemical used to kill

Hibernate

To spend the cold months in

Instinct

The natural behavior of an animal in response to environmental factors or other influences

Interdependent

Depending on or needing each other

Invasive

Regarding plants, coming from the outside and tending to spread and crowd out native plants

Invasive species

Non-native plants or animals that tend to spread or multiply in a way that crowds out or kills native species

Landscape

A large outdoor area with plantings and natural features

Leaf litter

The layer of fallen leaves, twigs, and other natural organic matter

Marsh

An area where the land is low and wet

Migratory

Adjective to describe a bird or other animal that migrates

Native

Originally from a particular place, rather than coming from or being

Naturalist

A person who is interested in, observes, and values nature

Natural resource

Something that occurs in nature and can be used for a beneficial

Noctural

Active at night

Nurture

To take care of and encourage growth

Nutrient

Something such as a vitamin or mineral needed by living things to grow and stay healthy

Organic

Grown or raised without the use of pesticides and other chemicals

Organism

A living plant or animal

Orient

To figure out where one is in relation to one’s surroundings

Perennial

Plants that live through all seasons of the year

Photosynthesis

The entirity of organisms and their environment.

Pollen

The powdery material produced by plants that is transferred from flower to flower, making it possible for plants to reproduce

Pollinator

An organism, such as an insect or a bird, that transfers pollen from one plant to another

Pollution

Harmful substances (solid, liquid, gas) that get into air, water, and soil because of human activities

Precipitation

Water that has evaporated and then falls from the sky in the form

Rain garden

A garden containing native plants, designed to catch or slow down rainwater runoff, helping to filter out pollutants before they reach

Respiration

The entirity of organisms and their environment.

Runoff

Material carried by rainwater into rivers, lakes, and the ocean

Shrub

A low-growing plant with woody

Species

A group of plants or animals that share certain characteristics and are able to breed and reproduce

Sustainable

Able to be done without harming the environment or using up resources

Threat

Something that could cause injury, damage, or death

Urban

In a city; relating to the characteristics of a city

Watershed

The entire area from which water drains into a particular river, lake,

Weed

A plant that grows where it is not wanted

Wetland

An area, such as a swamp, marsh, or lake, that is sometimes or always covered with water or where the soil is always saturated

Wildlife

Resources

BOOKS

[The Urban Naturalist](#)

[The Lorax](#)

[Seeds of Change](#)

[Sand County Almanac](#)

[Silent Spring](#)

[Braiding Sweetgrass](#)

[Can You Hear the Trees Talking?](#)

[Diary of a Young Naturalist](#)

[One Earth: People of Color
Protecting Our Planet](#)

[Where the Crawdads Sing](#)

[Rewilding the Urban Soul](#)

[Field Notes from a
Catastrophe](#)

[Any Pennsylvania
Plant Field Guides](#)

YOUTUBE



[Pest Control](#)

“Ask an Arborist: How do I Check for Tree Pests?”
<https://youtu.be/LUShQaEXmMA>

[Pruning](#)

“Ask an Arborist: The ABC’s of Pruning”
<https://youtu.be/IQhmlK-0HOc>

[Watering](#)

“10 Ways to Water Your Garden Better”
<https://youtu.be/ueQCtSD5AdM>

[Planting Trees & Shrubs](#)

“How to plant a tree in a few easy steps: TREE GUIDE 101”
<https://youtu.be/KEdHR11djPU>

[Planting Perennials](#)

“GARDEN WITH ME | PLANTING SEEDLINGS + BUILDING A RAISED GARDEN BED”
https://youtu.be/MXf_ZTq1Emw

“How Urban Farming Saved a Dallas Community”
https://youtu.be/gfCcl6_1iiA

“A guerilla gardener in South Central LA”
https://youtu.be/EzZzZ_qpZ4w

“Pollination (self & cross) | How do organisms reproduce”
<https://youtu.be/hClOCHwrJdQ>

“The hidden beauty of pollination | Louie Schwartzberg”
https://youtu.be/eqsXc_aefKI

“Pollination (self & cross) | How do organisms reproduce”
<https://youtu.be/hClOCHwrJdQ>

WEBSITES

New Jersey Weed Gallery
<https://njaes.rutgers.edu/weeds/>

Farmer’s Almanac
Common Weeds
<https://www.almanac.com/content/common-garden-weeds>

Gangsta Gardener

<https://ronfinley.com/pages/about>

PHILLY

Philadelphia Horticultural Society
<https://phsonline.org/>

Agriculture in Philly
<https://www.phila.gov/programs/farmphilly/>

Fairmount Park Horticulture Center
<https://myphillypark.org/explore/parks/fairmount-park-horticulture-center/>

PEOPLE OF INTEREST

5 Historic Black Figures in Horticulture, Gardening and Plant Sciences You Should Know

<https://dmbotanicalgarden.com/5-historic-black-figures-in-horticulture/#:~:text=1.,many%20other%20ways%20as%20well>.

Walter Hood

<https://www.macfound.org/fellows/class-of-2019/walter-hood#searchresults>

John Bartram

<https://www.bartramsgarden.org/bartram-history/>